

Deferred, not Eradicated: The Presupposition of Universality in Heidegger

This essay evaluates Heidegger's *Being and Time* in response to early-to-mid-Husserl's phenomenological project. I will, first, introduce Husserl's project; second, present Heidegger's critique of Husserl; third, critique Heidegger's approach; lastly, comment on the limitations of my critique. I argue that while Heidegger addresses certain presuppositions that early-to-mid-Husserl rests upon, Heidegger's 'solution' nonetheless still rests upon a further assumption of *universality*. In fact, Heidegger's approach, in focusing on the murky notion of 'being', potentially makes this assumption even more problematic than in Husserl's case.

A Presuppositionless Ground: Husserl's Phenomenological Project

Husserl saw phenomenology as a way to establish a ground for the sciences. Husserl lamented that sciences of his time were following a *natural attitude*: in which one "executes the acts of experiencing, referring, [and] combining" (2002, 128) objects in the world of our experience, with the focus-of-analysis on these *objects* rather than on *the acts of consciousness that makes possible these objects of experience*. Husserl believed that the natural attitude does not sufficiently account for the ways in which our consciousness makes possible such objects of experience. To ground our scientific discussions, he believed that we need to first understand the structures of our consciousness. This is what Husserl took to be the task of phenomenology.

In order to do so, early-to-mid-Husserl emphasised the *phenomenological attitude*, which seeks to bracket (*epoché*) the *noema* (i.e. the contents of our experience; e.g. an apple tree) from the *noesis* (i.e. the structures of consciousness in which this content appears to us; e.g. our perception of the tree as a single, enduring object, even as its shape changes with the wind). Husserl asserted that isolating the noesis as our focus-of-study allows us to "*enquire purely*



into this mental process itself” (136). Additionally, to further integrate the role of attention into his system, mid-Husserl also introduces the *Ego-ray*, which he believes to be an attentional ray that “[emanates] from the pure Ego” (143) and is directed onto objects of our experience. This introduction of the ego allows Husserl’s system to better explain how one’s consciousness organises various mental acts (e.g. listening to a lecture even as a dog barks in the background).

Overall, Husserl stressed the “*principle of freedom from presuppositions*” (75). By focusing his analysis on the structures of consciousness, Husserl believed that phenomenology could establish this presuppositionless ground and “transform [sciences] into true, methodical, [and] fully self-justifying sciences” (88).

Husserl’s Presupposition of the Ego: Heidegger’s Response to Husserl

Heidegger’s *Being and Time* (2010) can be read as building upon Husserl’s goal of establishing a ground for the sciences, one that is free from presuppositions. However, whereas Husserl saw the structures of consciousness to be most fundamental, and thus to be the starting point of our analysis, Heidegger argued that this approach nonetheless pre-supposes two things: Firstly, the existence of an ego; secondly, that the structures of consciousness can be studied via a bracketing of the contents of our experience.

Heidegger challenges Husserl’s presupposition that there exists an “initially given ego” (45). Heidegger argues that “[every] idea of a “subject” ... still posits the *subjectum ontologically* along with it” (45). In other words, Heidegger’s critique is that Husserl’s posit of the ego—and more generally the focusing of analysis on the structures of consciousness—already presupposes a particular ontology which has yet to be understood; as such, Husserl’s system fails to meet his own principle of ‘freedom from presuppositions’. For Heidegger, the most

fundamental notion, upon which all sciences rest, is *being*. Thus, achieving Husserl's goal of establishing a presuppositionless ground for science would, for Heidegger, "[require] a preliminary understanding of 'what we really mean by this expression 'being''" (10).

Additionally, Heidegger critiques Husserl's method, of *noesis-noema epoché*, for already mistakenly assuming that the way we experience the world can be isolated from the contents of our experience. Heidegger challenges this by suggesting that, at the most fundamental level, we understand ourselves not as some "objectively present" thing via an "indifferent" attitude (42), but rather in a relational way between ourselves and the (supposedly external) world. That is, our ways of experiencing the world and ourselves are already situated within the world. The ways through which we experience the world is termed *Dasein* (~being-in-the-world).

Heidegger seems to regard *Dasein* as *universal*, in that it is the way through which *all* humans experience the world.¹ Firstly, he asserts that the "'universality' of being 'surpasses' ontology" (2), suggesting that 'being' is fundamentally universal. Next, he goes on to establish the link between 'Dasein' and 'being', asserting that *Dasein* is the "being, which *we ourselves in each case are*" (7; italics added). In this line, we see Heidegger's suggestion that the structure of *Dasein* is universally applicable to all humans (persons who participate in scientific enquiry).

Overall, Heidegger believes that it is through an existential analysis of *Dasein* (i.e. examining how *Dasein* experiences the world) that we can achieve an understanding of fundamental ontology, which can then ground the sciences in a way that is free from presuppositions.

¹ To be sure, from the onset Heidegger rejects the notion that 'being is the most universal concept'; however, what he takes issue with is not with the *universality* of being but instead the (mistaken) understanding of 'being' as a *concept*.

A Merely Deferred Presupposition: An Evaluation of Heidegger

Heidegger's work is successful in exposing major presuppositions upon which Husserl's project rests. Indeed, early-to-mid-Husserl's focus—on “*pure* reflection *exclusively*” and on bracketing all “objects *alien* to consciousness” (2002, 129; italics added) in order to elucidate “the *totality* of his *purely* mental processes” (1971, 80; italics added)—does suggest an underlying assumption: that there exists some *pure* consciousness that can be grasped in its totality by isolating it from all noematic content. This notion of pure, isolated consciousness has a Platonic flavour to it, in that there exists, as Plato believed, some unchanging, absolute, and universal form that is prior to, and can be separated from, our everyday experience in the world. By challenging notions such as the ‘pure ego’ and ‘essence’, Heidegger elegantly exposes the ontological presuppositions that much of post-Socratic philosophy rests upon.

To be sure, this is not to say that Heidegger necessarily rejects Husserl's system, only that this system is not yet grounded in an understanding of fundamental ontology. Here, Heidegger can be interpreted as seeking to establish a foundation upon which Husserl's phenomenology could then build (Moran, 2000). Overall, by illuminating the question of ‘what is being?’, Heidegger succeeds in opening up an important set of hitherto-neglected questions for us to explore.

However, despite his success in exposing the presuppositions of Husserl's project and in re-directing our focus of discussion, Heidegger's own positive solution falls short of a presuppositionless philosophy. In particular, I argue that Heidegger's project still rests upon the presupposition of *universality*, of which he does not sufficiently justify.



One such instance of this is in Heidegger's assumption that the sense of ‘self’ is universal to all Dasein. In discussing the “existential question of the who of Dasein” (2010, 111), he asserts

that “the who is answered in terms of the I itself, the “subject”, the “self””, and that “this subject has the character of the *self*” (112; underline added). Herein lie two presuppositions that Heidegger makes. Firstly, his discussion of our experience of the ‘who’ already rests upon a preliminary understanding of this ‘who’, even as he seeks to unpack it. It is not certain that all Dasein experience the ‘who’ in such ways; neither does Heidegger further justify this assertion.



Secondly, Heidegger’s discussion here presupposes that a sense of the “I itself” (henceforth *I-sense*) is a universal feature of all Dasein. Going a step further, this I-sense is presented by Heidegger as not only universal, but in fact an *essential and constitutive* component of Dasein. As he asserts, “[the] being whose analysis our task is, is *always* we ourselves [i.e. Dasein as *self-relatedness*]. The being of this being is *always* mine [i.e. Dasein as *mine-ness*]” (41; italics added). In presenting the elements of ‘self-relatedness’ and ‘mine-ness’ as “characteristic of Dasein” (41), Heidegger stakes his discussion of Dasein squarely upon an I-sense. However, it is questionable whether this I-sense is indeed a universal experience of all humans.²

The lack of adequate justification in Heidegger’s presupposition towards universality is problematic for two reasons. Firstly, many of Heidegger’s assertions in *Being and Time* seek to describe inner, subjective experiences; for example, how we *experience* space, death, and objects in the world. In fact, this is precisely Heidegger’s project: To discard the ‘objectively present’, and to focus on the subjective ways in which we experience the world as Dasein. However, herein lies a challenge for Heidegger, for he seeks to hold ‘describing inner, subjective experiences’ in tandem with ‘maintaining claims towards universality’. This is tricky because the nature of one’s subjective experiences is often thought to be not fully

² To be sure, Heidegger does give a reason for the I-sense, positing that anxiety (in the face of impending death) “individualises and thus discloses Dasein as “solus ipse”” (182). However, this merely defers the presupposition of universality, for it is unclear if everyone experiences impending death this way. For example, in Buddhism, *arahants* are suggested to be without self-conceit; if so, the way ‘death’ structures their Dasein may be different.

accessible to others. Insofar as this is so, then Heidegger's analysis of Dasein, in seeking to encompass the structural ways in which *all* of us (at least, humans who participate in scientific enquiry) experience the world, is also staked upon the assumption that all other Dasein experience the world in the same way as he does.³



The second reason that inadequate justification is problematic is that the terms Heidegger seeks to unpack are often either murky (e.g. 'being') or used unconventionally (e.g. 'Dasein', 'Care') in that they take on new, technical meanings in Heidegger's system. Heidegger himself admits, for example, that our understanding of 'being' is "vague" (4). Given this murkiness and novelty, it is especially important for Heidegger to provide clear reasons in support of his analysis.



These reasons should also be independently verifiable, in that they should appeal to a common ground upon which we can assess the 'truth' of his statements. But as rigorous and systematic as Heidegger may be, his project's aim of preceding all objectivity also means that, for readers, the only ground we have when assessing his statements is that of our own individual experience.

Taken together, the lack of an independently verifiable common ground means that any reader can reject Heidegger's claims by saying: "No, this is not how I experience the world (or space, or things etc.)"; and Heidegger is unable to reject these claims. If such an individual can be found, then Heidegger is left with three options: (1) assert that the individual's claims are simply wrong—only that Heidegger would be unable to prove his claim any more than she is unable to prove hers—or (2) admit that Dasein is not universal to all humans; or (3) admit that his analysis is not universal to all Dasein. '1' seems unsatisfactory; '2' and '3' both gravely undermine the possibility that his project could serve as a foundational ground for all sciences.

³ Heidegger can push back by suggesting that one Dasein can, in fact, access the Dasein of someone else, and thus that his claim towards universality is not mere speculation, but borne instead from accessing and being with the Dasein of others. However, once again, this merely defers the problem, because that this supposed 'ability to access another Dasein' is arguably also an inner subjective claim of which some individuals may reject.

To be sure, such a critique also applies to Husserl's phenomenological project. However, I argue that with Heidegger, the challenge becomes even more problematic, due to the increased murkiness of the ideas that he seeks to discuss. Indeed, this seems to be the trap that Heidegger faces, due not to any fault of his own but simply the very nature of the project he undertakes.

Don't Throw the Baby Out with the Bathwater: Continuing Heidegger's Project

Even so, such challenges do not render Heidegger's arguments invalid. At best, it shows that his claims are not apodictically certain and that there lies the possibility that these claims are not universal. Despite this, I contend that Heidegger's project can continue nonetheless.

As murky as it may appear, Heidegger's approach of questioning the fundamental ontology of 'being' may still be a plausible way forward. If we seek to establish a ground that precedes logical analysis, and if fundamental ontology is not an objective thing but rather a necessarily subjective experience, then the lack of an independently verifiable common ground is not a bug, but a necessary feature, of our project, for it indicates that we are shifting the analysis away from the objective and towards an inner, murkier, yet more fundamental ground.

Furthermore, the world that each of us experiences is, indeed, *potentially* a common ground upon which we can discuss and test our claims' extent to universality. While the possibility of one's claims being refuted always remains, this does not mean that we should 'throw the baby out with the bathwater' and not begin any analysis at all. Instead, we can proceed with a 'first pass' into unpacking the structure of 'being', as Heidegger has done. When disagreements arise, these points can then be taken up for further discussion and, from there, refined in a way that is agreeable to all sides. While Heidegger's analysis may not be indubitable, his question "what is 'being'?", and his analysis, do provide a starting point for us to critique and build upon.



References

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